



DEMYSTIFYING MUSICAL INTERVALS

INTRODUCTION:

Understanding and mastering musical intervals is crucial for any guitarist looking to elevate their skills. Intervals are the building blocks of chords, scales, and melodies. This guide will break down the types of intervals, how to recognize them on the guitar fretboard, and provide effective practice routines to solidify your understanding.

SECTION 1: WHAT ARE MUSICAL INTERVALS?

Musical intervals refer to the distance between two notes. This distance can be measured in terms of **steps** (whole steps and half steps) or **semitones** (frets on the guitar). Intervals are categorized by their size (number of steps) and quality (major, minor, perfect, augmented, or diminished).

INTERVAL NAMING AND TYPES:

Each interval has a specific name that corresponds to the number of notes it spans in a diatonic scale. For example, C to E is a **major 3rd** because it includes three note names (C, D, E).

Common Intervals and Their Names:

1. Unison (Perfect 1st)
2. Minor 2nd (1 semitone)
3. Major 2nd (2 semitones)
4. Minor 3rd (3 semitones)
5. Major 3rd (4 semitones)
6. Perfect 4th (5 semitones)
7. Tritone (6 semitones)
8. Perfect 5th (7 semitones)
9. Minor 6th (8 semitones)
10. Major 6th (9 semitones)
11. Minor 7th (10 semitones)
12. Major 7th (11 semitones)
13. Octave (Perfect 8th – 12 semitones)



SECTION 2: UNDERSTANDING INTERVAL QUALITIES

The quality of an interval determines its **sound and harmonic character**. Below is a breakdown of the different qualities:

- **Perfect Intervals:** Unison, 4th, 5th, and Octave. These intervals are neither major nor minor and are considered stable and consonant.
- **Major Intervals:** 2nd, 3rd, 6th, and 7th. Major intervals are a half step larger than their minor counterparts.
- **Minor Intervals:** A minor interval is a half step smaller than a major interval.
- **Augmented Intervals:** One semitone larger than a perfect or major interval.
- **Diminished Intervals:** One semitone smaller than a perfect or minor interval.

Why Do Intervals Matter?

Intervals form the foundation of chords and scales. Understanding them enables you to:

- Construct chords in different positions on the fretboard.
 - Build and navigate scales efficiently.
 - Improve your ear for identifying and creating harmonies.
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SECTION 3: VISUALIZING INTERVALS ON THE GUITAR FRETBOARD

Finding Intervals on the Fretboard:

To find intervals on the guitar, it's essential to memorize the fretboard. Below are a few methods to visualize intervals:

1. Single-String Approach:

- Play a root note on a string.
- Move up or down the number of frets corresponding to the desired interval.
- Example: To play a **perfect 5th** above C (3rd fret, A string), move 7 frets up to G (10th fret, A string).

2. Horizontal and Vertical Patterns:

- Learn the horizontal (across one string) and vertical (across multiple strings) relationships.
- Example: A major 3rd above C (5th string, 3rd fret) can be played by moving 4 frets up (C to E) or moving to the 2nd fret on the D string.

3. Common Shapes and Positions:

- Memorize common interval shapes like major/minor 3rds, perfect 5ths, and major/minor 6ths.

SECTION 4: PRACTICE ROUTINES FOR GUITAR

Routine 1: Single-String Interval Exercises

1. **Goal:** Develop a sense of distance and recognition of intervals.

Exercise:

- Start with a root note on any string (e.g., C on the 5th string, 3rd fret).
- Play intervals up and down the string (minor 2nd, major 2nd, minor 3rd, etc.).
- Repeat on each string, naming the interval as you play it.

Routine 2: Interval Identification Across Strings

1. **Goal:** Learn to identify intervals across different strings.

Exercise:

- Choose a root note on one string.
- Play a 3rd (major and minor) on the adjacent string.
- Move through 4ths, 5ths, and 6ths using different root positions.



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Routine 3: Chord Construction Using Intervals

1. **Goal:** Use intervals to build chords.

Exercise:

- Start with a root note on the 5th or 6th string.
- Play the major 3rd, perfect 5th, and octave to create a major triad.
- Experiment with minor 3rds, augmented 5ths, and diminished 7ths to create different chord voicings.

Routine 4: Interval Training with Scales

1. **Goal:** Practice intervals within the context of a scale.

Exercise:

- Choose a scale (e.g., C major).
- Play and sing (YES, SING!) the intervals within the scale: root to 2nd, root to 3rd, root to 4th, root to 5th, root to 6th, root to 7th and finally root to 8th.
- Ascend and descend the scale, focusing on intervals.

Routine 5: Ear Training for Intervals

1. **Goal:** Develop the ability to identify intervals by ear.

Exercise:

- Play an interval (e.g., C to E for a major 3rd) and hum the interval.
- Test yourself by playing random intervals and guessing their names.



SECTION 5: APPLYING INTERVALS IN REAL MUSIC

Understanding intervals isn't just about theory—it's about application. Use intervals to:

- Compose melodies that move smoothly.
- Create harmonies in soloing or accompaniment.
- Explore new chord voicings and transitions.

Experiment with intervals in different keys and positions to unlock new creative possibilities on the guitar.

Conclusion

By mastering musical intervals, you gain control over the fundamental elements of music, making it easier to navigate the fretboard and create expressive compositions. Use the provided exercises regularly to internalize these concepts and see significant improvements in your playing.

If you'd like more guidance, feel free to explore advanced lessons on harmony, chord construction, and scale applications!